secretary questioning the pricing formula, was evidence of its complicity in this alleged wrongdoing.

It was not as if I was a completely unblemished hero in the 2G drama. Both the PAC (Public Accounts Committee) and the JPC (Joint Parliamentary Committee), while acknowledging my diligence in raising the pricing formula, pulled me up for not sufficiently following up on my letter. But all that is a different story and a deviation from my main narrative here. In the context of the main story—my extension—the speculation was that the government would not give me one because it was cut up with me for the embarrassment my letter had caused to the UPA leadership.

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I went to meet the prime minister at his official residence at 7 Race Course Road on 21 July 2011 as part of my regular pre-policy briefing ahead of the quarterly policy review scheduled for 26 July. This was roughly seven weeks before my three-year term was to expire. After we finished the substantive business of the meeting, he asked me if I had met the finance minister and briefed him on the policy. I told him I had. He paused for a while and I remained quiet, as gaps of silence were quite common in one-on-one conversations with Dr Manmohan Singh. ‘Has the finance minister spoken to you about your extension?’ he then asked me, and I said no. ‘You are doing well at RBI and there is no reason why you should not serve a full five-year term like others.’ This was more of self-musing rather than a question. After another awkward pause, I stood up to take leave, and then he said, ‘Let me know as soon as the finance minister speaks to you.’

I returned to Mumbai and got caught up in the hurly-burly of the policy review and follow-up tasks. It was not as if the uncertainty of an extension was burdening my mind. There was still more than a month to go, and given the government’s standard practice of eleventh-hour appointments, I knew it was too early to feel at a loose end.